letters to do anything. So maybe the NLD can change that system", she explained. Conversation then turned to an upcoming pagoda festival in Taungoo, sponsored by the chairman of CB Bank U Khin Maung Aye. They were planning to attend. "We heard it will be the biggest festival ever held in Taungoo", the patriarch said. "That man [Khin Maung Aye] does a lot of good things for Taungoo", he opined.

CONCLUSION

As Myanmar embarks on a transition from decades of authoritarianism to a form of governance more firmly grounded in 'popular' sovereignty, ideas of 'the political' are emerging that are deeply rooted in moral and religious spheres of social action. For many, the central networks and relationships in their lives are linked to local social and welfare groups intimately tied to religious institutions, ideas, and discourses of merit, compassionate social action, and the value of life. With regime approval and oversight, these groups have increasingly filled the welfare vacuum left by the absence of the state since the mid-1990s. Since the liberalization of 2011, the arenas of social action offered by these networks have helped to popularize a notion of 'politics' that frames propagation and protection of Buddhism as a religion essential to the national psyche and character, and fundamental to notions of 'security'.

In the context of a thin welfare state, thick conceptualizations of moral citizenship and sovereignty are emerging. One of the legacies of Myanmar's authoritarian period is thus the creation of a polity where political claim-making does not necessarily occur via the ballot box. Rather, notions of entitlement and cultures of reciprocity are deeply embedded in social action — frequently of a small 'p' political nature — which seeks to supplement, complement, and increasingly navigate the web of Myanmar's nascent democratic state. In the context of Myanmar's 2015 elections, small 'p' politics of this sort ensured that a formal electoral process was lent a distinctly Buddhist nationalist character. Social welfare groups and networks are working as 'informal' political institutions, essential to the everyday interactions from which political imaginaries and notions of sovereignty and citizenship are being generated.[16] The interaction between formal political actors and these 'informal' political institutions rooted in the legacies of a weak authoritarian state are thus likely to be essential to